

Voters in Texas show favor for the center

Trump could blunt Democrats’ momentum with key endorsement

BY LIZ GOODWIN AND KAREN TUMULTY

Texas primary voters of both parties voted with cool heads Tuesday, rejecting candidates who appealed to their parties’ bases with more inflammatory styles that could have proved riskier in a general election.

But challenges still remain for Democrat James Talarico — who won the primary outright on a unifying message of reaching out to all Texans — and for Republican Sen. John Cornyn, who nosed ahead of firebrand Attorney General Ken Paxton but now faces a punishing May 26 runoff against him. On Wednesday, President Donald Trump announced on social media that he soon would pick a candidate in that runoff and expects the other person to drop out immediately.

Democrats face an uphill battle to flip a Senate seat in the red state no matter what happens in the runoff, as they mount their long-shot bid to retake the Senate in November. The chamber is currently controlled by Republicans, 53 to 47, and Democrats must flip several deep-red states like Texas to regain control.

“Talarico’s victory is a big step forward in our quest to win back the Senate,” Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) told reporters Wednesday.

The next few months will determine how well-positioned Texas

SEE TEXAS ON A2

Democratic primary: Talarico tops Crockett for Senate nomination. A3

ICE may close detention site by Fort Bliss, file shows

BY DOUGLAS MACMILLAN

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement is taking steps to close Camp East Montana, a massive immigrant detention camp near the Mexican border that opened less than eight months ago, according to an internal ICE document reviewed by The Washington Post.

The document, distributed to agency staff this week, indicated that ICE is drafting a letter to terminate the facility’s contract, but did not give any timeline or reason for the decision. The \$1.2 billion contract, awarded to Acquisition Logistics LLC in July of last year, had an estimated date of completion of Sept. 30, 2027.

Lauren Bis, a spokeswoman for the Department of Homeland Security, said in a statement that the department is reviewing Camp East Montana to ensure it meets standards, and that “no decisions have been made related to contract extension, termination, or award.”

“ICE is always looking at ways to improve our detention facilities to ensure we are providing the best care to illegal aliens in our custody,” Bis said. “DHS undergoes rigorous audits and inspections of our facilities to ensure they are meeting our high standards.”

SEE FORT BLISS ON A2

A rapid reforging of the Middle East



BADERKHAN AHMAD/AP

Shepherds in eastern Syria inspect an unexploded Iranian projectile that landed in an open field on Wednesday. An Iran-led order that long backed the likes of Hamas, Hezbollah and the Houthis is gone, 29 months after the Hamas-led attacks.

Amid feud, Anthropic’s AI tool Claude central to U.S. campaign

BY TARA COPP, ELIZABETH DWOSKIN AND IAN DUNCAN

In order to strike a blistering 1,000 targets in the first 24 hours of its attack on Iran, the U.S. military leveraged the most advanced artificial intelligence it’s ever used in warfare, a tool that could be difficult for the Pentagon to give up even as it severs ties with the company that created it.

The military’s Maven Smart System, which is built by data mining company Palantir, is generating insights from an astonishing amount of classified data from satellites, surveillance and other intelligence, helping provide real-time targeting and target prioritization to military op-

erations in Iran, according to three people familiar with the system.

Embedded into the system is Anthropic’s AI tool Claude, a technology that was banned by the Pentagon last week after heated negotiations over the terms of its use in war.

Over the last year military planners have seen Claude, paired with Maven, mature into a tool that is in daily use across most parts of the military, according to two of the people.

As planning for a potential strike in Iran was underway, Maven, powered by Claude, suggested hundreds of targets, issued precise location coordinates, and prioritized those targets according to importance, said two of the

SEE ANTHROPIC ON A7

Pentagon plays down concerns as U.S. burns through munitions

BY NOAH ROBERTSON, DAN LAMOTHE, WARREN STROBEL AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

The Pentagon is rapidly burning through its stocks of precision weapons less than a week into the massive campaign of airstrikes against Iran, while also expending sophisticated air defense missiles at a rate that puts the U.S. military potentially “days away” from having to prioritize which targets to intercept, according to three people familiar with the matter.

The scope of “Operation Epic Fury,” which U.S. Central Command’s Adm. Brad Cooper says has hit more than 2,000 targets so far, is forcing U.S. military commanders to make difficult

calculations about how quickly their Iranian adversaries will burn through their own munitions — even as President Donald Trump says the war may last four to five weeks.

Top Pentagon leaders dedicated considerable time at a news briefing Wednesday morning to addressing worries the military is reaching too deeply into its inventory at the cost of readiness. “We have sufficient precision munitions for the task at hand, both on the offense and defense,” said Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, without offering specifics or numbers.

The United States will rely on its larger stores of less-sophisticated weapons as Iranian defenses

SEE IRAN ON A7

OCT. 7 LIT FUSE THAT UPENDED REGION

Its foes mostly crushed, Israel stands as hegemon

BY STEVE HENDRIX

JERUSALEM — Early on a cool autumn morning in 2023, from a tunnel beneath the Gaza Strip, Yahya Sinwar gave an order that sent thousands of Hamas fighters through the fence separating the territory from Israel. That green light has reordered the Middle East on a scale comparable to the Arab Spring or the carving up of the Ottoman Empire in the early 20th century — but not remotely in the ways Sinwar had in mind.

Twenty-nine months later, the Middle East is almost unrecognizable. Israel stands indisputably as the military hegemon, its enemies demolished or decapitated. Saudi Arabia is emerging as a pivotal economic and political anchor, its Persian Gulf neighbors reeling under Iranian missile fire. Palestinians, mourning 75,000 dead in a shattered Gaza and losing territory in the West Bank, seem marginalized — by everyone, again.

Sinwar is dead — assassinated by Israel in October 2024 — and after nearly two and a half years of bloodshed and upheaval, the network he hoped would ride to his rescue is in ruins. Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was blown up in a joint U.S.-Israeli airstrike on Saturday. The regime that bankrolled and armed the “axis of resistance” for four decades is on the edge of collapse — perhaps taking with it Hamas, Hezbollah and the Houthis.

Tehran, facing a chaotic and uncertain succession, is making enemies of the entire region — firing drones and missiles haphazardly, and often vainly including civilian targets. Bashar al-Assad, the longtime Syrian ruler, now lives in frigid Moscow.

Driving the military campaign and aiming to shape the region’s future is Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who has survived

SEE MIDDLE EAST ON A15

Reservists mourned: Four killed in Kuwait have been identified. A6

MAGA revolt: Trump fires back at right-wing mutiny over Iran. A6

Funerals in Iran: Children killed in a strike on a school are buried. A14

LOU HOLTZ 1937-2026



PHIL SANDLIN/AP

Hall of Fame college football coach dies

Lou Holtz is carried off the field after Arkansas upset Oklahoma in the 1978 Orange Bowl. Holtz, who led Notre Dame to the 1988 NCAA national title, later became a broadcaster. **Obituary, B15**

Why flu has been getting worse than covid in winter

Unusual strains partially explain the difference in severity over time

BY FENIT NIRAPPIL

Heard about a lot of people getting flu this winter but not much about covid?

It’s not just you. For the second winter in a row, the United States has faced a punishing flu season, with covid as a more muted threat.

Early in the covid pandemic, coronavirus proved far more transmissible and deadly as it ripped through the world than the flu typically was. Flu was almost nonexistent that first pandemic winter in 2020-2021.

Now that SARS-CoV-2 is no longer a novel virus sweeping through a population with little immunity, covid and influenza illnesses are becoming more similar, with a key difference: Coronavirus circulates year-round

and ticks up in the summer, when flu is gone.

Does that mean flu is now the woe of the winter, and covid is the scourge of the summer? It’s complicated and too soon to say.

“We don’t know where covid is going. I really don’t think we know what is the next season going to look like,” said Manisha Juthani, Connecticut’s top public health official and president of the Association of State and Territorial Health Officials.

“But we do know we have an intervention that still helps protect people for both, for flu and covid,” she added, referring to vaccines.

William Schaffner, a professor of infectious diseases at Vanderbilt University, said people should expect variation in the rise and fall of respiratory viruses.

“They don’t all hit home runs,” he said. “But some of them hit triples and doubles and singles, and the individual patient doesn’t care which virus it was that put them in the hospital.”

SEE ILLNESS ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Peak bloom pushed back The famed cherry blossoms in D.C. are likely to take their time this year, following the chilliest winter in more than two decades. B13

Texas primary runoff Rep. Tony Gonzales (R-Texas) is facing an ethics investigation over an alleged affair with a former aide. A3

THE NATION Voters should have patience with the pace of economic improvements, Vice President JD Vance said in an interview, adding there was “no way” to fix the economy overnight. A5

THE WORLD Six U.S. troops killed by a drone strike in Kuwait had little protection, imagery shows. A15 Spain’s prime minister delivered a rebuke to Trump’s war in Iran, escalating their feud. A16

THE ECONOMY The U.S. Senate is moving ahead with a bipartisan package to bring down housing costs, including new grants and a ban on institutional investors. A20 U.S. stocks rebounded from two days of punishing swings after oil stopped spiking. A20

STYLE ‘Love Story’ revives interest in the iconic styles of JFK Jr. and Carolyn Bessette. B13

SPORTS The U.S. will be trying for its first World Baseball Classic championship since 2017 as play gets underway at the Tokyo Dome. B7

THE REGION Body-camera footage from at least two federal law enforcement shootings in D.C. last fall may soon become public. B13

LOCAL LIVING ‘House Hushing’ is a simple home organizing technique that can help you turn down the volume on visual clutter.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A20 COMICS.....B4 OBITUARIES.....B16 OPINION PAGES.....A17 TELEVISION.....B6 WORLD NEWS.....A14

CONTENT © 2026 The Washington Post Year 149, No. 54511

0 70628 21100 3